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E2 Speaking & Listening – Exam Prep Lesson 2: Describing people, places and things – Lesson plan and answers

Learners finish able to describe a picture for about a minute in an organised way: the whole scene first, then the people, the place and the things in it, then an opinion. This prepares Task 3.

Materials: Handout E2-2A, one per learner. Eight printed colour photos, A4 if possible, numbered on the back: a street market with stalls and shoppers; a family eating together at home; a busy bus stop in the rain; a park with children playing; a kitchen with someone cooking; a classroom with adult students; a high street with shops; a living room with a sofa, table and television. One extra photo to project or hold up for modelling. Plain paper for drawing.

Activity 1: Whole, parts, opinion (25 minutes, teacher-led)

1. Show the modelling photo. Ask: “What can you see?” Take single words and write them around the board with no order.
2. Now describe the picture yourself for one minute in an organised way. Start with the whole scene, move from left to right, describe one person in detail, and finish with an opinion.
3. Ask what you said first, next and last. Board the three stages: *the whole picture; the parts; my opinion*.
4. Build the language under each stage with the class. Whole: *This is a picture of… It is in a… I think it is morning.* Parts: *On the left there is… In the middle there are… At the back I can see… She is wearing… He is carrying…* Opinion: *I think they are… because… I like this picture because… It looks…*
5. Drill the position phrases with gestures. Point left, right, middle, front, back and have learners call the phrase. Then reverse: you say the phrase, they point.
6. Check the grammar that the assessor listens for: *there is* with one thing and *there are* with more than one; *is* or *are* plus the *-ing* verb for actions happening now. Board two wrong sentences, *There is three people* and *He wear a hat*, and have the class correct them.

Activity 2: Model description with gaps (20 minutes)

1. Hand out E2-2A. Learners read the description in section A and fill the gaps from the box, alone.
2. Pairs compare. Check as a class by reading the text aloud and pausing at each gap for the class to call the word.
3. Ask learners to mark the three stages in the margin: W for whole, P for parts, O for opinion.
4. Pairs read the completed description aloud to each other, one sentence each in turn. Listen for *there is* and *there are* and correct on the spot.

Activity 3: Describe and draw (25 minutes)

1. Seat pairs back to back. Give A a photo and B a sheet of plain paper.
2. A describes the photo for three minutes. B draws what they hear and may ask questions: “Where is the woman? What is she wearing? How many people are there?”
3. Pairs compare the drawing with the photo. They find three things that are different and say them aloud: “In the photo there are two children, but in the drawing there is one.”
4. Swap roles with a new photo.
5. Feedback: ask which words were missing when learners got stuck. Board them. These are usually position words and clothes.

Activity 4: Better words for people, places and things (20 minutes, teacher-led then pairs)

1. Draw three columns on the board: *people, places, things*. Ask learners to complete section B of the handout by sorting the adjectives into the columns. Some words fit in more than one.
2. Check and drill the pronunciation of *crowded, comfortable, friendly* and *modern*.

3. Teach comparing in one line each: *The market is busier than the park. The sofa is more comfortable than the chair.* Short words add *-er*; long words use *more*.
4. Pairs take two photos and make three comparing sentences. Hear one from each pair.

Activity 5: Exam simulation (30 minutes)

1. Explain the task: each learner gets a picture and describes it to their partner and the assessor. Aim for about a minute without stopping.
2. Groups of three: speaker, partner, timekeeper. The speaker takes a photo they have not seen. The timekeeper gives ten seconds to look, then starts the clock.
3. The speaker describes the picture using whole, parts, opinion. The partner listens and then asks one question about it.
4. The timekeeper reports the time and gives feedback from section C of the handout.
5. Rotate until everyone has spoken twice with different photos. Move between groups and note common errors.
6. Last five minutes: board five errors you heard, without names. The class corrects them together.

Answer key, E2 Lesson 2

- **Section A:** 1 left, 2 behind, 3 wearing, 4 middle, 5 are, 6 carrying, 7 is, 8 because.
- **Section B, suggested:** People: tall, friendly, young, old, tired, busy, quiet. Places: crowded, quiet, modern, busy, old, expensive. Things: heavy, modern, comfortable, old, expensive.